Udet first sat in the cockpit of a Messerschmitt Bf 109, he is said to have remarked that "this would never be a fighting airplane" because "the pilot has to feel the air to know the speed of the plane." It was a prejudice shared by many old-school pilots, brought up on "flying by the seat of your pants." But they could not argue with the speed – typically 300–350mph (480–560kph) – or rate of climb of the new models, which was combined with a breathtaking capacity to dive, spin, and roll that made them among the most exciting aircraft to pilot that have ever been created.

Heavy bombers

For most American and British air commanders, however, the crucial airplanes in their force were not the fighters but the heavy bombers. The US Army Air Corps and the RAF held that strategic bombing could be a war-winning use of air power, given the right aircraft to do the job. In Britain, Trenchard and other commanders drew support for this view by arguing that a bomber fleet would allow the British to fight a war in Europe without sending an army across the Channel – and a repeat of the trench warfare

WILLY MESSERSCHMITT

Willy Messerschmitt (1898–1978) built gliders as a teenager before World War I. Exempted from war service due to ill health, in the 1920s he began designing powered aircraft. From 1926 he had his aircraft built by BFW (Bayerische Flugzeugwerke), and he subsequently took over the company. During the vicious infighting of the Nazi regime after 1933, Messerschmitt had to cope with the hostility of the powerful state-aviation boss Erhard Milch and the bitter rivalry of designer and manufacturer Ernst Heinkel.

The adoption of the Bf 109 by the Luftwaffe in 1935 made Messerschmitt's reputation, and he renamed the BFW as Messerschmitt AG in 1938. He experimented with mixed success at the cutting edge of aviation technology, producing, among other models, the Komet rocket aircraft and the Me 262 jet fighter. After the defeat of the Nazis, Messerschmitt took refuge in Argentina, but in the 1950s he returned to Germany to continue his career.

INSPIRED DESIGNER
An inspired designer, Willy Messerschmitt was also capable of basic errors and miscalculations.

Messerschmitt Bf 109

In 1935 the Messerschmitt Bf 109 was selected as the Luftwaffe's new single-seat monoplane fighter after demonstrating its excellent handling and a high performance in competitive flight trials. It was a remarkably advanced example of the all-metal monoplane designs being introduced at that time – small, with a lightweight construction and a thin wing section to give the highest possible performance. Novelties, compared with the previous generation of fighters, included the enclosed cockpit and electric starter for the propeller. Leading-edge slats and slotted flaps were used to alter the shape of the wing (optimized for maximum speed) to perform adequately at slow speed for landing.

The Bf 109 was bloodied in the Spanish Civil War, where it won air superiority for the German Condor Legion. The 109E, developed in 1938, was the first true mass-production model of the basic design and became the most famous model, proving itself a match for RAF Spitfires and Hurricanes during the Battle

> "The new Bf 109 simply looks fabulous. The takeoff is certainly unusual but... its flight characteristics are fantastic."
>
> **Johannes Trautloft**
> Condor Legion pilot

LIFE JACKETS REQUIRED
Luftwaffe fighter pilots wore life jackets during the Battle of Britain. The limited range of the Bf 109 meant that it was a common experience for pilots to run out of fuel over the Channel (on the way home). This necessitated "ditching" in the sea.